

Salary Negotiation Playbook

CareerForge Knowledge Base · Volume 5

Why this matters more than it feels like it does: A single successful negotiation compounds across every future raise and offer that's benchmarked against it. Not negotiating is rarely the safe choice -- it's usually the expensive one.

1. Preparation: Know Your Number Before Any Conversation

- Research market rate from multiple sources (salary aggregation sites, industry surveys, your professional network) and triangulate rather than trusting one number.
- Factor in your specific variables: location, company size/stage, years of experience, and specialized/high-demand skills.
- Decide your target, your walk-away minimum, and an ideal number above target -- know all three before any conversation starts.
- Understand the full compensation package, not just base salary: bonus structure, equity/stock, retirement matching, health benefits, remote/flexibility policy, learning budget, PTO.

2. Core Negotiation Principles

- **Let them anchor first when possible.** Whoever states a number first gives away information; if asked for your range early, redirect politely ("I'd like to learn more about the role's scope first") or give a well-researched range rather than a single figure.
- **Negotiate the whole package, not just base.** If base salary is fixed by a band, sign-on bonus, equity refresh, start date, or title can often still move.
- **Always counter, even to a reasonable-looking offer.** A first offer is rarely a company's true ceiling; countering signals you know your worth and costs you nothing but a short conversation.
- **Use silence deliberately.** After stating your ask, stop talking. Resist the urge to fill silence with a concession -- let the other side respond first.
- **Get everything in writing.** Verbal promises during negotiation should be confirmed in the written offer before you resign from a current role.

3. Scripts for Common Situations

Countering an initial offer (email)

"Thank you for the offer -- I'm genuinely excited about the role and the team. Based on my research into market rate for this role and level, and the scope we discussed, I was hoping we could get closer to [target number]. Is there flexibility here?"

When asked for your salary expectations too early

"I want to make sure any number reflects the full scope of the role -- could you share the budgeted range for this position first? I'm confident we can find alignment."

Negotiating a raise at your current company

"Over the past [period], I've [specific accomplishment with measurable impact]. Based on that and current market rates for this role, I'd like to discuss adjusting my compensation to [target]. What would you need to see from me to make that happen?"

Using a competing offer (carefully)

"I want to be transparent -- I've received another offer at [range, without necessarily naming the company]. I'd genuinely prefer to stay here; is there room to close that gap?"

4. Using AI Tools in Negotiation

AI-powered tools can quickly summarize market compensation data, industry trends, and suggest a negotiation range -- genuinely useful for preparation. But employers increasingly expect candidates to use these tools, so the differentiator is no longer having the data; it's combining that data with your specific, personal achievements and framing them persuasively yourself.

5. Common Mistakes

- Accepting the first offer without countering at all.
- Giving a specific number before doing any market research.
- Treating negotiation as adversarial rather than collaborative -- the goal is a package that makes both sides happy to move forward.
- Negotiating only base salary and ignoring equity, bonus, and start date, which are often more flexible.
- Making an ultimatum you're not actually prepared to follow through on.
- Failing to get a verbal agreement confirmed in writing before resigning elsewhere.

6. Quick Checklist

- ■ Researched market rate from 2+ independent sources
- ■ Know my target, ideal, and walk-away numbers
- ■ Considered the full package, not just base salary
- ■ Prepared 2-3 specific, quantified achievements to justify the ask
- ■ Practiced saying the number out loud, then staying silent
- ■ Will get any verbal agreement confirmed in writing

This guide reflects widely-observed hiring practices and 2025-2026 industry trends. It is general career guidance, not a guarantee of interview or offer outcomes -- always adapt advice to your specific role, industry, and location.